

CLUE & CANDLE GAMES PRESENTS

HOST GUIDE

The Last *Countdown*

A Cozy New Year's Eve Murder Mystery Party Game

6-16 PLAYERS

2.5-3 HOURS

PRINTABLE PDF

Timed to end at midnight · 12 character booklets · Letter + A4



CLUE & CANDLE GAMES COZY · NO GORE · NO DRINKING REQUIRED

Welcome, Detective



Thank you for hosting! Tonight your guests become the suspects at **The Pendleworth Countdown Gala** in the little town of Larkhaven, and you play **Detective Rowan Hale**, the investigator who must name the guilty party before Old Lark strikes midnight. You are not a suspect, so you can play along without knowing the answer until the end.

How the game works

STEP	WHAT HAPPENS
1 • Invite	Give each guest a character and an invitation (file 02 or the E-Invites).
2 • Set up	Print, cut and lay out the evidence table (about one hour).
3 • Play three rounds	Guests read one round at a time from their booklet, mingle, question each other and study new evidence.
4 • Accuse and reveal	Everyone fills in a ballot; you read the solution and lead the countdown.

What you need

- ◆ A printer (black-and-white works) and scissors
- ◆ One envelope per guest (optional, for booklets)
- ◆ A small table for evidence, plus pens for every guest
- ◆ A two-pronged paper fastener for the countdown clock prop
- ◆ Punch, sparkling cider, cocoa or soft drinks: no alcohol is needed for any part of the game

YOUR ROLE

You hold the timeline and the scripts. You never need to know the answer until 11:45 pm; file 99 stays sealed until then. If you would rather not know, ask a friend to print it for you.

CASTING

You play the Detective and do not need a booklet. Give the six core booklets (10–15) to the guests you are surest will come; add optional characters (16–21) in order as your list grows.

Preparation checklist



Two weeks before

- ☐ Read this guide and 00-START-HERE (not file 99)
- ☐ Choose Midnight Edition or Family Early Countdown (pages 7–8)
- ☐ Count your guests and pick characters with the casting table (page 5)
- ☐ Send invitations: printed (file 02), E-Invites, or Invitation-Maker.html

One week before

- ☐ Collect RSVPs; confirm who plays which character
- ☐ Plan food and drinks (page 14)
- ☐ Print booklets single-sided, one per guest, and put each in an envelope with the guest's name
- ☐ Print and cut evidence cards (file 30, pages 1–2), name tags and ballots

Two days before

- ☐ Print Script pages from this guide, or keep it open on a tablet
- ☐ Assemble the countdown clock prop (file 35, page 1)
- ☐ Cut out the Chime Cards (file 35, page 2)
- ☐ Optional: print awards, table signs, banner and photo props

On the day

- ☐ Put booklets, name tags and Detective Notes by the door
- ☐ Keep the evidence cards in three piles, in order: E1–E4, E5–E8, E9–E12
- ☐ Print file 99 last, fold it, and keep it in your pocket
- ☐ Set a phone alarm for each Chime Card time

SOMEONE CANCELS?

Check the removable-characters table on page 6. Optional characters (16–21) can be removed at any time without changing the solution. For a core character, ask another guest to take the booklet on.

One-hour setup plan



TIME BEFORE GUESTS	TASK
60 min	Clear a table for evidence. Add the “Evidence Table” sign (file 34). Stack the three evidence piles face down, in order.
50 min	Pin up the countdown clock prop where everyone can see it. Set the hands to 9:00 (or 6:30 for the Family edition).
40 min	Lay out name tags, Detective Notes and pens by the door, with the booklets in named envelopes.
30 min	Drinks and snacks out: label them with the round names from page 14.
20 min	Decor: banner, photo props, the scene sign (file 34).
10 min	Read Script 1 once to yourself. Put the Chime Cards in your pocket with file 99.
0 min	Music on. Greet your first suspect!

Setting the scene

- ◆ Lay a few clocks or watches around the room; ask a guest to bring an old alarm clock as the “stopped clock”.
- ◆ A blue mug on the evidence table makes a perfect stand-in for Ellis’s cup.
- ◆ Use gold and silver ribbon, star confetti and fairy lights for the gala look.
- ◆ Play gentle swing or piano music during the rounds, and turn it down for each script.

TIP

If you have more than ten guests, set up two small evidence tables with a full copy of the evidence on each (print file 30 twice).

Who plays whom



Add characters strictly in this order. Booklets 10–15 are the core six: the game is complete with only these. Each optional character (16–21) adds new red herrings and extra witness statements.

PLAYERS	CHARACTERS TO USE
6	10 Avery Vale · 11 Parker Brightwell · 12 Reese Calloway · 13 Emerson Quill · 14 Harper Lune · 15 Devon Ashby
7	The six core + 16 Kit Sterling
8	+ 17 Sage Whitfield
9	+ 18 Rory Penhallow
10	+ 19 Blair Okafor
11	+ 20 Dakota Fenwick
12	+ 21 Marley Ashgrove (all twelve)

13 to 16 players

PLAYERS	PLAN
13	All twelve characters + 1 Deputy Detective (no booklet; uses Detective Notes and a blank name tag, helps you place evidence and reads Chime Card 2)
14	Twelve characters + Deputy + 1 pair: two guests share one optional booklet (print a second copy)
15	Twelve characters + Deputy + 2 pairs
16	Twelve characters + Deputy + 3 pairs

PAIRS

Pairs play one character together, for example the Mayor and the Mayor's deputy, or the Pianist and the band's singer. Pair up optional characters (16–21) only; each partner gets their own copy of the booklet and both vote. The Deputy Detective can also be a teenager or someone who prefers not to act.

GENDER-NEUTRAL ROLES

Every character works for any guest. Change pronouns freely; no booklet uses he or she for a suspect.

Removable characters



Optional characters can be removed in reverse order (21 first, then 20, and so on). The solution in file 99 relies only on the evidence cards and the six core booklets, so removing any optional character never breaks the case.

#	CHARACTER	IF REMOVED
21	Marley Ashgrove , Society Photographer	The 10:12 photo strip (E9) still exists; just say the booth ran itself.
20	Dakota Fenwick , Fireworks Master	Fewer fireworks hints; the letter (E8) still tells the story.
19	Blair Okafor , Town Historian	Lose some Old Lark history; nothing else changes.
18	Rory Penhallow , Keeper of the Clock Tower	The tower punch card (E7) still works on its own.
17	Sage Whitfield , Gala Pianist & Bandleader	Treat the toast rehearsal as led by the band.
16	Kit Sterling , Antique Dealer	Drop one red herring about a fake watch.

NEVER REMOVE

Characters 10–15 are needed in every game. If a core guest cancels on the day, give that booklet to an optional guest and remove the highest-numbered optional character instead.

EVIDENCE

Always use all twelve evidence cards, whatever the number of players. Optional booklets mention some cards, but no card depends on an optional character being present.

9:00 pm to midnight



Every segment adds up to 180 minutes. The reveal starts at 11:45 pm and the countdown begins at 11:59 pm.

START	END	MIN	SEGMENT	WHAT TO DO
9:00	9:15	15	Arrivals	Name tags on; guests read booklet pages 1–2. Hand out Detective Notes.
9:15	9:25	10	Script 1	Welcome and the case.
9:25	9:30	5	Script 2	Rules; place E1–E4 on the evidence table.
9:30	10:00	30	Round 1	Guests read Round 1 and mingle.
10:00	10:03	3	🕒 Chime Card 1	Read it; set the clock prop to 10:00.
10:03	10:05	2	Script 3	Place E5–E8.
10:05	10:45	40	Round 2	Mingle; snack break halfway.
10:45	10:48	3	🕒 Chime Card 2	Read it; set the clock to 10:45.
10:48	10:50	2	Script 4	Place E9–E12.
10:50	11:30	40	Round 3	Final round of questions.
11:30	11:33	3	🕒 Chime Card 3	Ballots out.
11:33	11:45	12	Accusations	Ballots filled in; 20-second final statements.
11:45	11:59	14	Script 5 · reveal	Read the solution from file 99.
11:59	12:00	1	Countdown	Everyone counts down from 10.
Total		180	minutes · 9:00 pm to 12:00 am	

AFTER THE CLOCK STRIKES · 12:00–12:05 AM

Hugs, a toast with sparkling cider or cocoa, then the three awards (file 34). Not counted in the 180 minutes.

STARTING LATE?

10 minutes late: cut Arrivals to 10 and Accusations to 7. **20 minutes late:** also cut Round 2 and Round 3 to 35 minutes each. **30 minutes late:** also cut Round 1 to 25 and Script 1 to 5. Never cut the reveal or the countdown; move Chime Cards with the rounds.

6:30 pm to 9:00 pm



For families, teens and early nights: 150 minutes, the reveal at 8:45 pm and an early countdown at 8:59 pm. The Chime Cards show the Midnight Edition times; in this edition, read them at 7:20, 7:54 and 8:28.

START	END	MIN	SEGMENT	WHAT TO DO
6:30	6:40	10	Arrivals	Name tags on; booklet pages 1–2.
6:40	6:48	8	Script 1	Welcome and the case.
6:48	6:50	2	Script 2	Place E1–E4.
6:50	7:20	30	Round 1	Mingle.
7:20	7:22	2	🕒 Chime Card 1	Read it (ignore the printed time).
7:22	7:24	2	Script 3	Place E5–E8.
7:24	7:54	30	Round 2	Mingle; snack break.
7:54	7:56	2	🕒 Chime Card 2	Read it.
7:56	7:58	2	Script 4	Place E9–E12.
7:58	8:28	30	Round 3	Final questions.
8:28	8:30	2	🕒 Chime Card 3	Ballots out.
8:30	8:45	15	Accusations	Ballots; short statements.
8:45	8:59	14	Script 5 · reveal	Read file 99.
8:59	9:00	1	Early countdown	Count down from 10; New Year cheer.
Total		150	minutes · 6:30 pm to 9:00 pm	

STARTING LATE?

10 minutes late: cut Arrivals to 5 and Accusations to 10. **20 minutes late:** also cut Round 2 and Round 3 to 25 minutes each. **30 minutes late:** also cut Round 1 to 25 minutes and Script 1 to 3 minutes. Keep the reveal and the countdown.

MIDNIGHT LATER?

Some families do the early countdown, put the little ones to bed, and repeat the countdown at midnight with the clock prop.

Script 1 • Welcome and the case

**READ ALOUD • 9:15 PM (FAMILY 6:40)**

Good evening, everyone, and welcome to Larkhaven! I am Detective Rowan Hale, and I am very sorry to say this is not an ordinary New Year's Eve.

Tonight, the town gathered at Pendleworth & Co. Clockworks, at the foot of the Larkhaven Clock Tower, for the Pendleworth Countdown Gala. There was punch, sparkling cider, cocoa, a band, a raffle and a photo booth.

At 10:15, Master Clockmaker Ellis Pendleworth was due to announce who would inherit the keys to Old Lark, the great town clock that rings in every New Year. Ellis never came out to make it.

At 10:28, Ellis was found in the workshop, asleep at the workbench, and could not be woken. Someone had added something to Ellis's cocoa. The little mantel clock in the workshop had stopped at 9:42.

Every one of you was at the gala. Every one of you had a reason to be cross with Ellis, and every one of you is hiding something.

By the time Old Lark strikes midnight, we will know who did it. Until then, nobody leaves the gala!

THEN

Ask each guest to introduce their character in one sentence, using page 1 of their booklet (name, role, and one thing everyone knows about them).

Script 2 • The rules

**READ ALOUD • 9:25 PM (FAMILY 6:48)**

Here is how tonight works. In your booklet you will find three rounds. Read a round only when I announce it.

Each round tells you what to share, what to ask and one small task. You may stretch the truth to protect your secret, but you must never deny something printed on an evidence card.

If you are innocent, you may still lie about your secret, but not about the crime. If someone asks you a direct question about the gala timeline, answer as your booklet says.

New evidence appears on the evidence table at the start of each round. Study it, talk about it, and write down what you learn on your Detective Notes.

At the end, everyone accuses someone on a ballot. Points for who, how, why and the key clue. The best detective wins a prize.

Round 1 starts now: open your booklet to page 3 and read Round 1 only. The first four pieces of evidence are on the table.

THEN

Turn over E1–E4 on the evidence table. Walk around, listen, and nudge quiet guests with “Who here have you not spoken to yet?”

Scripts 3 and 4



READ ALOUD · SCRIPT 3 · AFTER CHIME CARD 1 · 10:03 PM (FAMILY 7:22)

Thank you, everyone. Round 1 has stirred up a few surprises, and some of you are already looking at each other differently.

New evidence has just arrived from the workshop, the kitchen and the tower stairs. Four new cards are now on the table.

Please read Round 2 in your booklet, below the dashed line on page 3, and nothing more.

Some of you will have to admit something tonight. Better to tell the truth now than to be caught out later. Round 2 begins!

READ ALOUD · SCRIPT 4 · AFTER CHIME CARD 2 · 10:48 PM (FAMILY 7:56)

We are close now. The last four pieces of evidence have been found, and they are on the table.

Turn to page 4 and read Round 3. This is your final chance to ask, to explain and to point a finger.

Look again at every card. Think about time: who could have been where, and when?

At the next chime, ballots come out, so make your questions count. Round 3 begins!

The countdown clock and the Chime Cards



Build the clock (file 35, page 1)

- ◆ Print page 1 on card stock if you can. Cut out the two hands.
- ◆ Push a two-pronged paper fastener through the dot on each hand and the centre of the dial.
- ◆ Pin or tape the clock somewhere everyone can see it, next to the evidence table.

How to use it

- ◆ Set it to the start time when guests arrive.
- ◆ Each time you read a Chime Card, move the hands to the time on the card: 10:00, 10:45 and 11:30 (Family: 7:20, 7:54, 8:28).
- ◆ At the reveal, set it to 11:59 and leave it there until the countdown.
- ◆ During Round 3, players may want to use it to act out the stopped clock theory. Let them!

The Chime Cards (file 35, page 2)

- ◆ Three cards, read at 10:00, 10:45 and 11:30. Each ends one round and starts the next.
- ◆ Ring a bell, tap a glass with a spoon, or play a chime sound on your phone first.
- ◆ The cards contain no answers, so a Deputy Detective or a guest can read them for you.

PHONE ALARMS

Set three silent alarms with the labels “Chime 1”, “Chime 2” and “Chime 3”. They keep the night on time without you watching the clock.

Keeping it fun



- ◆ **Start on time.** Late arrivals can join during Round 1; they read pages 1–2 while others mingle.
- ◆ **Talk to everyone.** As the Detective, ask each guest one question per round. It gets shy players talking.
- ◆ **Encourage costumes** but never require them. A single prop (a key, a camera, a clipboard) is enough.
- ◆ **Keep the evidence moving.** Pick up a card and read it aloud if nobody has looked at it for ten minutes.
- ◆ **Quiet guest?** Point them to their task for the round. Every task is designed to start a conversation.
- ◆ **Someone guesses early?** Wonderful. Smile, say “Interesting!”, and keep going. Ballots decide the winner.
- ◆ **Lost the thread?** Ask the room for a 60-second recap at the start of each round.
- ◆ **Children and teens:** the game contains no gore and no drinking. Teens can play any character; younger children make good Deputy Detectives.
- ◆ **Work parties:** the content is office-safe. Use the Family Early Countdown for a two-and-a-half-hour event at any time of day.
- ◆ **Keep file 99 sealed** until 11:45, and keep your own reactions neutral when guests theorise.

AWARDS

Best Detective goes to the top ballot score (ties: whoever handed in first). Best Costume and Best Bluffer are decided by a show of hands at 12:00.

Decor, props, drinks and snacks



Decor and props

- ◆ Midnight blue, gold and silver: tablecloth, streamers, star confetti.
- ◆ Clocks everywhere: borrowed alarm clocks, a paper clock garland, watches on the table.
- ◆ The “Happy New Year” banner and photo props in file 35.
- ◆ Table signs from file 34: the scene sign at the door, “Evidence Table: Do Not Touch” by the cards.

Alcohol-free drinks and snacks, named by round

ROUND	DRINK OR SNACK	IDEA
Arrivals	Pendleworth Punch	Cranberry juice, orange juice and sparkling water with orange slices.
Round 1	Workshop Cocoa Bar	Hot cocoa with whipped cream, marshmallows and cinnamon sticks.
Round 2	Old Lark Cider Fizz	Sparkling apple cider in tumblers with a cinnamon stirrer.
Snack break	Clockwork Cookies	Round biscuits iced as clock faces, with the hands at 11:59.
Round 3	Raffle Popcorn	Sweet and salty popcorn in paper cones, plus a cheese board.

EVERY DRINK IS OPTIONAL

Nothing in the game asks anyone to drink anything. Toast with whatever is in your hand.

Booklets, cards and paper



Character booklets

- ◆ Each booklet is its own file (10 to 21): exactly 4 pages, one character only.
- ◆ **Print single-sided.** Then Round 2 and Round 3 cannot show through the back of an earlier page.
- ◆ Staple the top-left corner, or fold the stack in half and slip it into a named envelope.
- ◆ Optional: cut along the dashed line on page 3 and hand out Round 2 separately when you read Script 3.
- ◆ File 22 contains all twelve booklets in one file. Each booklet starts on an odd page (1, 5, 9 ... 45), so if you print double-sided no two characters share a sheet. Single-sided is still safest.

Cards and cut sheets

- ◆ Evidence cards (file 30): print pages 1–2. For backs, print page 3 on the reverse side (flip on the long edge).
- ◆ Name tags (file 31), ballots (file 32), invitations (file 02) and Chime Cards (file 35): cut along the dashed lines.
- ◆ Card stock (160–200 gsm / 65–80 lb) makes cards and the clock sturdier; ordinary paper works too.

Paper size and colour

- ◆ Use the **US-Letter** folder in North America and the **A4** folder elsewhere. Print at “Actual size” or 100%.
- ◆ Everything is designed to print clearly in black and white; the round of each evidence card is marked with one, two or three stars.

PRINT 99 LAST

Print the solution yourself, at the very end, without reading it. Fold it in half and keep it with you.

On the night



WHEN (MIDNIGHT)	FAMILY	DO THIS
9:00	6:30	Name tags, booklets, Detective Notes
9:15	6:40	Script 1 (page 9)
9:25	6:48	Script 2 · E1–E4 out
10:00	7:20	Chime Card 1 · Script 3 · E5–E8
10:45	7:54	Chime Card 2 · Script 4 · E9–E12
11:30	8:28	Chime Card 3 · ballots
11:45	8:45	Open file 99 · Script 5
11:59	8:59	Countdown!
12:00	9:00	Awards and cheers

Troubleshooting

IF...	THEN...
A guest arrives late	Give them their booklet and a one-line recap; they can skip Round 1's task.
A core guest cancels	Give their booklet to an optional guest; remove the highest-numbered optional character.
The room goes quiet	Ask the guest who has not spoken yet to do their task now.
Running long	Cut the next round by 5 minutes. Keep 11:45 for the reveal.
Running early	Add a “press conference”: each suspect answers one question from the room.
Ballots tie	Best Detective goes to whoever handed in first.

REMEMBER

You are Detective Rowan Hale. Ask questions, keep time, and enjoy watching your friends lie beautifully.